C1 Speaking

Signposting in presentations

Phrases that guide listeners through a talk: opening, moving on, giving examples and concluding.

Listeners cannot scroll back to check what you said. Signposts are short phrases that tell them where they are in your talk, what is coming next and how ideas connect. Clear signposting makes a presentation sound organised even when the content is complex.

Stage	Useful phrases
Opening and outline	*Today I'd like to talk about... I've divided my talk into three parts.*
Starting a point	*Let's start with... The first thing I'd like to look at is...*
Moving on	*That brings me to my next point. Turning now to... Moving on to...*
Giving examples	*To illustrate this,... A case in point is...*
Referring to visuals	*As you can see from this chart,... If you look at the figures on the left,...*
Digressing and returning	*Just a quick aside,... Coming back to my main point,...*
Summarising and concluding	*To sum up,... So, to recap the main points,... I'll finish by...*
Handling questions	*I'd be happy to take any questions. That's a good question; let me come back to it at the end.*

Pause after a signpost. A one-second pause after *That brings me to my next point* gives listeners time to close the last idea and get ready for the next one.

Common mistake. Reading slides aloud. Use a signpost to frame the slide (*This chart shows how sales changed after the launch*), then talk to the audience, not to the screen.

Practice

Write a signpost for each situation.

1. You have finished your first point and want to start the second.
2. You want the audience to look at a graph.
3. You want to give a real example of a general claim.
4. You are about to finish your talk.
5. Someone asks a question that you plan to answer later.

▼ **Show answers**

1. That brings me to my second point. / Turning now to...
2. As you can see from this graph,...
3. A case in point is... / To illustrate this,...
4. To sum up,... / So, to recap the main points,...
5. That's a good question; let me come back to it at the end.